talk to the press directly'. Anirudhya hoped to stretch the brief meeting to a not-so-brief one.

Kaarthikeyan received Anirudhya with warmth, and did not expect a point-blank question to start with.

'Can you please show me the rest of the nine photographs from Haribabu's camera, Mr Kaarthikeyan?'

'What makes you so sure that they are in my custody?' Kaarthikeyan asked with a somewhat sarcastic smile.

'It's all over the press, sir.'

'The press is doing its job—it writes whatever it considers right. I cannot comment on that.'

'All right, sir. Have you got them or not?' Anirudhya was all smiles.

'I have got them. But it's too early for me to talk about them.'

While Anirudhya was looking for his next question, the SIT chief looked like the meeting was over. But Anirudhya was not calling it quits so soon.

'You can talk about the photograph that's already published in *The Hindu*. After all, sir, the SIT has not denied anything about it.'

Kaarthikeyan looked at his watch and said it was 'tiffin time'—would Anirudhya like to join him? Anirudhya jumped at the invitation. Such things always granted a reporter more time with sources.

Kaarthikeyan and Anirudhya went to the dining hall. There was a buffet system—coffee, tea, masala vadai, steaming idli, medu vada, mini-sized imarti and sweet rava. Seeing the boss walk in, the staff already present made way for him and exchanged greetings. Kaarthikeyan filled a plate with 'tiffin' and gave it to Anirudhya and then served himself just two idlis. Was he on a diet? 'No, no. I keep eating throughout the day.'

Meanwhile, other senior officers had joined. Kaarthikeyan introduced Anirudhya to all of them, not even missing one. Anirudhya understood that the seasoned cop was treating Anirudhya with all the respect and attention but creating a situation where Anirudhya would not be comfortable asking questions.

Among the officers who had joined Anirudhya knew a few. Amit Verma grinned from ear to ear when he saw Anirudhya. Kaarthikeyan noticed,